Thesis Title

Thesis Subtitle



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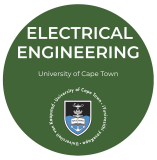
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Keywords: keyword1; keyword2; keyword3



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Mon 12 October, 2026

Abstract

Thesis Title

Joab Gray **Kloppers**

Mon 12 October, 2026

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List of Symbols

Symbol	Description	Unit
$\boldsymbol{B}$	Magnetic flux density	T
$\boldsymbol{E}$	Electric field	V/m
$\boldsymbol{J}$	Current density	A/m^2
t	Time	s
ε_0	Permittivity of free space (8.85×10^{-12})	$C^2/N{\cdot}m^2$
μ_0	Permeability of free space ($4\pi \times 10^{-7}$)	N/A^2

Chapter 1

Introduction

1.1 Background

1.1.1 Biological Activity

Sand prawn activity has a large effect on the surrounding ecosystem. Pillay and Branch [2] explain that by physically burrowing into the sediment, they distribute buried sediment to the surface, alter the surface structure via the introduced mounds, which can increase surface area, and alter both chemical and structural properties of the sediment through burrowing and nutrient mixing. Venter et al [3] further shows that sand prawn bi-directional water pumping filters can reduce phytoplankton biomass by up to 70% in estuarine environments which can help with ecosystem resilience.

1.1.2 Technical application

Schenone et al [1] demonstrates that surface microtopography can be used as a reliable metric to predict biochemical processes. However common metrics for measuring surface roughness characteristics such as (list them here) are often invasive and result in the damage of the very structures under measurement. Azhar et al [4] demonstrated that the use of low cost RGB-D cameras can be used to produce depth images of the sediment surface, which can then be processed to analyse the surface properties.

Sub-subsection

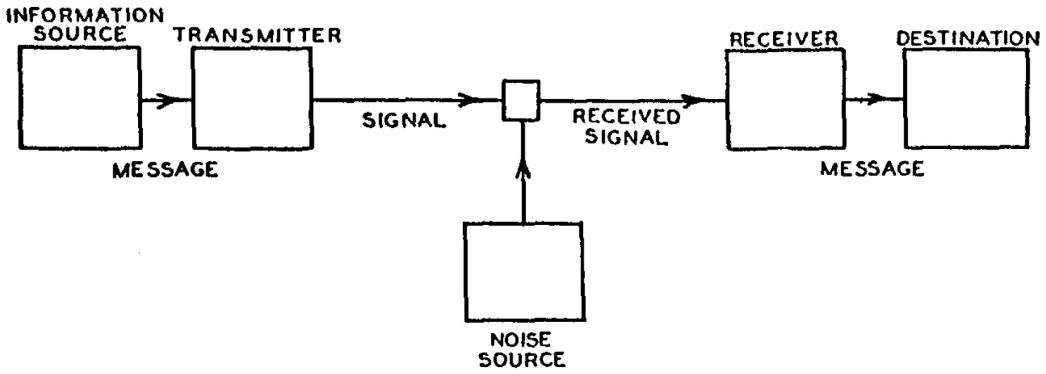


Figure 1.1: A simplified block diagram of a general communication system. A communication system can be abstracted as follows: an *information source* produces a message to be sent through a *transmitter* which converts it to a signal which can be sent via a communication *channel*. The received signal is noisy and is converted back to the message by the *receiver* which is then delivered to the *destination*. Taken from shannon1948

Table 1.1: Table title. Extended description of tables contents.

Heading 1	**Heading 2**	
	Subheading 1 [units]	*Subheading 2* [units]

1.2 Problem statement

Equations are numbered and include the chapter number. As they are considered part of the text, they include punctuation, and each parameter must be described in the text below. Ensure that the units are stated and where possible use SI units. For example, the Maxwell equations are expressed as:

$$\nabla \cdot \boldsymbol{E} = \frac{\rho}{\epsilon_0}, \tag{1.1}$$

$$\nabla \cdot \boldsymbol{B} = 0, \tag{1.2}$$

$$\nabla \times \boldsymbol{E} = -\frac{\partial \boldsymbol{B}}{\partial t}, \tag{1.3}$$

$$\nabla \times \boldsymbol{B} = \mu_0 \boldsymbol{J} + \mu_0 \epsilon_0 \frac{\partial \boldsymbol{E}}{\partial t}, \tag{1.4}$$

where $\boldsymbol{B}$ is the magnetic flux density in T, $\boldsymbol{J}$ is the total current density in A/m^2, $\boldsymbol{E}$ is the electric field in V/m, μ_0 is the permeability of free space ($4\pi \times 10^{-7}$ H/m), and ϵ_0 is the permittivity of free space (8.85 $\times 10^{-12}$ C^2/N·m^2).

1.3 Project objectives

The Global Positioning System (GPS) is used for positioning. The Marginal Ice Zone (MIZ) is of particular interest in the Southern Ocean (SO).

1.4 Scope, limitations and assumptions

1.5 Plan of development

Chapter 2

Literature review

2.1 Sandprawn Bioturbation and Ecological Significance

Pillay and Branch [2] describe how sand prawn species are prominent members in the benthic ecosystem. The sand prawns continuously change the sediment properties such as surface topography porosity and biochemistry, through actions such as burrowing and water pumping. These actions redistribute buried sediment to the surface which results in surface mounds which increase the effective surface area of the sediment by up to 15 times. Kristensen et al [5] further explains how thalassinid shrimp populations can turn up to 12kg of sediment per square meter per day. These mounds can increase the effective hydrodynamic resistance which can help to stagnate the water flow close to the sediment. While the paper mentions measurements specific to sand prawn species located in other regions, they provide an insight into approximate feature sizes that can be expected, for example *Callianassa subterranea* present in the North sea can produce mounds 5.4cm tall and 11.7cm wide, and *Pestarella candida*, located in the Mediterranean and Adriatic Seas, which can produce mounds 3cm tall and 15cm wide.

Venter et al [3] further explains how sand prawns, *Callianassa kraussi*, present in the South African coastlines and at the Langebaan Lagoon, function as prominent water filterers. Within the burrows they actively irrigate the sediment through bi-directional pumping of water to replenish oxygen levels within the burrows, and to remove waste products. This irrigation has a secondary effect where phytoplankton are filtered out of the water by the burrow walls. This filtering can help improve ecosystem resilience to harmful conditions such as nutrient pollution which promote phytoplankton blooms. In relation to this project, the papers methodology entails manual visual counting of burrow openings.

The next question with regards to biological activity, is weather surface roughness, specifically rugosity, is a valid measurement to gauge the underlying biological activity within the benthic ecosystem. To this, Schenone et al [1, 6] determined experimentally that analysing two dimensional surface rugosity, they were able to correlate surface roughness measurements with sub-surface activity. One paper [1] described the testing of a controlled laboratory environment to simulate the benthic ecosystem, which can be seen in Figure 2.1. They found that the simple two dimensional rugosity estimate managed to account for up to 61% of nutrient variability. The second paper[6] describes a more complex implementation, with the use of a single diver operated camera recording video of the sediment surface, and the use of visual based structure from motion (SFM) photogrammetry to obtain a three dimensional representation of the surface. similarly, the find that sediment microtopography explains up to 55% of species richness variance, which is of particular interest with regards to this project. These papers show that surface rugosity is a useful measurement when gauging biological activity, and they provide a useful insight into the computational pipeline which is used to convert from spatial meshes to elevation matrices, however there are considerations that need to be considered, these papers discuss fully submerged environments, thus the requirement of under water cameras and SFM, whilst this project focuses on tidally exposed surfaces, where fixed clear observations can be made with the use of a rig.

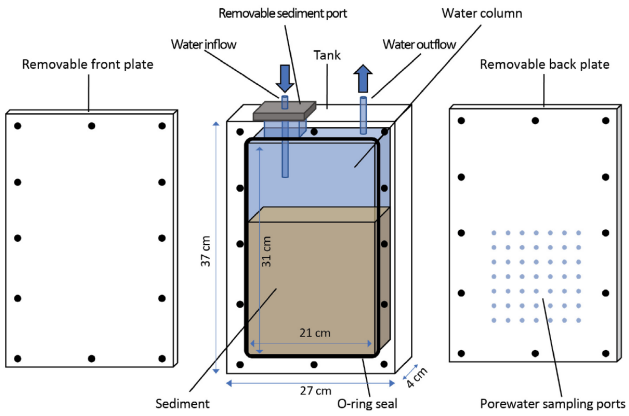


Figure 2.1: Custom incubation and flow through chamber by Schenone et al [1]

2.2 Surface Microtopography as a Proxy for Bioturbation

2.3 RGB-D Sensing for Non-Contact Surface Measurement

2.4 Summary and identified Research Gap

With the understanding that surface roughness statistics can provide a feasible proxy for benthic activity, there is a need for a method to scan sediment surfaces and extract topographical information. The current project, under the biological side **<PLEASE CHANGE THIS, SOMEHOW TIE IN THE EXISTING PROJECT>**, takes surface scans of static, exposed sediment, within the inter-tidal region in the Langebaan lagoon. These conditions mean that there is no need for submersion rated hardware, operated under dynamic conditions.

The current project is based off the work developed by Azhar et al [4]. The authors develop a framework that allows for extracting a millimetre scale 3D surface scans non-invasively, and at lower price scales than expensive LiDAR based systems. The system makes use of an off the shelf Asus Xiton pro Live 3D RGB-D structured light camera, mounted within an opaque plastic container to block infrared interference from sunlight. They then tested four polynomial de-trending algorithms to remove natural sediment gradients, and isolate the bioturbation. Due to the nature of the Asus Xiton, which makes use of structured light projection and a single IR camera, the system suffers when the surface is exposed to sunlight. Therefore the authors made use of an opaque plastic enclosure which is set on the sediment for scanning, however this limits the spatial resolution to only $0.3m^2$ with an effective camera resolution of only 240 x 200 pixels. Additionally the authors found that the higher order polynomial de-trending algorithms were sensitive to elevations at the edges of the image frame, requiring them to use a planar model which proved to be more robust.

Halmetschlager-Funek et al [7] and Rustler et al [8] provide useful insight by comparing several types of commonly available depth sensing cameras, encompassing different technologies such as structured light, active and passive stereo vision and time of flight (ToF). Halmetschlager-Funek et al [7] compares ten different sensors, with varying technologies and shows that sensor technologies like structured light and ToF generally struggle when exposed to high ambient light or reflective materials. These make it impractical to apply in the exposed environmental conditions considered for this project, as there is often direct sunlight, and small water pools which can increase reflectivity of the sediment. Rustler et al [8] compares four different stereo vision cameras, and finds that the Intel RealSense D435 is the superior camera for applications what are within one meter, however distance bias against planar surfaces increases significantly, compared to similar sensors such as the Intel RealSense D455, past 300cm distance. The author finds that for longer distance, the ZED 2 or Intel RealSense D455 are the best performers, with the main discerning factor being the image processing, as the ZED 2 requires dedicated GPU hardware for image processing, whereas the D455 does most of the processing on-board with some post precessing offloaded to the connected device.

Nguyen et al [9] discusses a method of deriving the lateral and axial noise profiles of the Microsoft Kinect using through analysis of specific scenes. To characterise lateral noise the authors make use of the fact the pixel statistical distributions along a depth edge are the same as statistical distribution of the point spreading factor (PSF), and thus can obtain a characterisation

on how points get blurred through the optics of the camera. For axial noise profiles, they analyse depth distributions across a plane of best fit, across various angles. Using these noise profiles, they are able to implement sensor specific filters that can filter noisy depth readings, whilst preserving geometric features. The benefit to this method is that it can be implemented across different sensors, enabling the application on the Intel RealSense D456 for improved depth filtering.

Metrological and critical characteriseation of intel d415 **<DONT THINK SHOULD USE THIS ONE>**

A benefit of using the Intel RealSense RGB-D cameras is the advanced ASIC which does all depth processing on device, thus eliminating the need for high performance computers during scans. Additionally the software development kit (SDK) for the RealSense family provides useful tools to the developer to tweak settings for specific applications, and to apply post-processing to scans for improved performance. Keselman et al, and Grunnet-Jepsen and Tong [10, 11] provide useful insight into the operation and theory of the Intel RealSense r200 and D400 series cameras respectfully. Keselman et al [10] describes how the correlation algorithm performs well under texture sparse conditions, and is more robust to noise compared to similar algorithms. The author also explains the limitations of the sensor, such as the minimum depth is dictated by the limited disparity search range, and maximum distance is limited by signal to noise ratio. Additionally, the use of a laser based feature projector can introduce some artifacting due to the effect of laser speckle noise. Grunnet-Jepsen and Tong [11] provide an outline on the post-processing methods provided by the Intel RealsSense SDK. This white paper explains how some of the processes work, and gives a general outline on the pipeline that should be applied to achieve a baseline filtered depth map.

One fundamental requirement of stereo vision is the need for textured surfaces, in order to perform disparity matching for depth computation. This need results as a reduction in performance on texture sparse environments. The Intel RealSense family address this with the use of a laser based IR projector which project semi random patterns onto the surface to artificially introduce visual texture. Grunnet-Jepsen et al [12] describes how the illumination power of the internal projector can be optimised for different light environments, and further how an external projector or dot pattern can be overlaid onto the surface to improve performance on texture sparse environments, as the D400 series cameras do not require a predefined pattern. These projected patterns can improve performance, as the achievable dot density is far higher than what the on board projector can achieve, and does not suffer with the same laser speckle problem.

<LOOK FOR A PAPER DISCUSSING TEXTURE OF WATER LOGGED SAND>

Intel Realsense camera depth testing methodology

pixel level extrinsics self calib??????

Chapter 3

Theoretical Backbone

3.1 Stereo Vision

3.2 Capture Alignment

3.3 Fusion

3.4 Evaluation

3.5 Roughness Calculation

3.6 Feature Detection

Table 4.1: System requirements and where they are addressed.

ID	Requirement	Addressed in
F1	Capture short-range depth scans of predominantly planar sediment	Sec. ??
F2	Restrict analysis to a repeatable, user-defined square region of the surface	Sec. ??, ??
F3	Capture the same surface from multiple viewpoints and fuse the scans into one reconstruction	Sec. ??
F4	Produce detrended microtopography, roughness metrics and segmented mounds and burrows	Sec. ??
E1	Allow working distance, viewing angle, lighting and depth-filter settings to be varied in a controlled, repeatable way	Sec. ??, ??
E2	Support characterisation of the camera's depth noise and error as a function of these conditions, to identify the optimal operating conditions for sediment	Chapter [TODO: ref]
E3	Measure the geometric error of fused scans under these conditions, and identify the optimal configuration for reconstruction	Sec. 4.5
C1	Use a single Intel RealSense D456	Sec. ??
C2	Rig is portable and adjustable in height for field deployment	Sec. ??
C3	Results are reproducible and comparable across runs and algorithms	Sec. 4.5

Chapter 4

System Design

This chapter defines the general requirements of the system as a whole and describes the hardware rig used to capture scans, and the software pipeline built to capture, and process the data to provide useful metrics about the sediment surface. The theory in Chapter [TODO: theory chapter ref] is applied here, and the sensor characterisation in Chapter [TODO: characterisation chapter ref] uses the system as specified below.

4.1 Requirements Definition

The aim of the overarching project is to quantify sandprawn bioturbation on intertidal sediment, within the Langebaan Lagoon, by measuring surface microtopography and extracting roughness metrics and visible biogenic features (mounds and burrow openings). The initial stages of the project were adapted from the framework of Azhar *et al.* [4], primarily modified to use the Intel RealSense D456.

This project aims to provide an investigation into the performance of the RealSense D456 camera currently used. The central aim is to characterise the depth camera in order to determine the optimal hardware and software configuration, and then to use scans taken under those configurations to build a high-quality reconstruction of the sediment on which the analysis is performed. The key output is an analysis of depth noise and reconstruction accuracy under different conditions.

Requirements are grouped as functional (F), experimental (E) and constraints (C), as shown in Table 4.1. Functional requirements state what the system as a whole must do. Experimental requirements state what system variables are investigated in the characterisation. Constraints are fixed conditions imposed on the design.



Figure 4.1: System overview. [TODO: Replace with a fuller diagram showing the data formats (.bag, .ply) passed between stages.]

4.2 System Overview

The system has three main operational stages, shown in Figure 4.1, with a fourth evaluation stage used for characterisation.

1. *Capture*: The capture software rs_marker scans the surface at multiple rotations and camera tilts.
2. *Fusion*: multi-angle scans are cropped to the tag-defined region, aligned and merged into a single reconstruction.
3. *Microtopography processing*: the fused surface is detrended, and roughness metrics and biogenic features are extracted.

For the purpose of characterisation, a fourth evaluation stage is used to gauge the reconstruction and metrics performance of the system against known target relief's.

4.3 Hardware Rig

4.3.1 Frame

The existing rig was built from 3030 aluminium extrusion in a $1\ \mathrm{m} \times 1\ \mathrm{m} \times 1\ \mathrm{m}$ frame. The top of the frame has a plastic tarp attatched, this allows for the shading of the scan area in the event of direct sunlight degrading the active stereo functionality of the D456. This frame was modified for the purpose of this project, in order to feature an H-shaped cross member that can slide vertically along the four legs. This enables the ability to adjust the camera height, and thus working distance, for purpose of characterisation and easy configuration. It was also modified to feature 3D printed April tag mounts that allow the position to be adjusted

4.3.2 Camera, Tilt and Rotation Mechanism

The Intel RealSense D456 is mounted on the H-frame through a 3D-printed bracket bolted to the extrusion. A servo motor in the bracket tilts the camera by up to $\pm 60°$. The camera clips onto a rotating platform on the tilt stage and can be turned manually through a full $360°$ in $45°$ increments. Together, tilt and rotation allow each surface point to be observed from several viewing directions, which reduces occlusion within burrows and mounds. This multi-view scanning additionally averages out view-dependent depth error. The servo is driven by an Arduino microcontroller, connected to and commanded from the operator's laptop, which also runs the capture software. The camera is operated at 1280×720 and 30 fps at a nominal working distance of [TODO: optimal distance].

4.3.3 AprilTag Boundary Markers

Four AprilTags are mounted on brackets on the frame legs, and each bracket can slide inward or outward. The tags' positions define a square region on the sediment surface to be processed and analysed. This gives a repeatable, physically marked analysis region, and its size can be changed to suit the desired scan region or height configuration of the camera. Because the tags are fixed to the frame, their detected positions also provide a geometric cue for aligning scans taken from different tilt and rotation settings.

Table 4.2: Hardware summary.

Component	Specification
Depth camera	Intel RealSense D456
Depth stream	1280×720, 30 fps
Working distance	≈700 mm
Frame	Aluminium extrusion, ≈1 m^3, sliding H-frame
Tilt actuation	Servo, ±60°, Arduino-controlled
Rotation	Manual, 45° increments, 360°
Boundary markers	Four adjustable AprilTags
Ambient light control	Overhead tarp

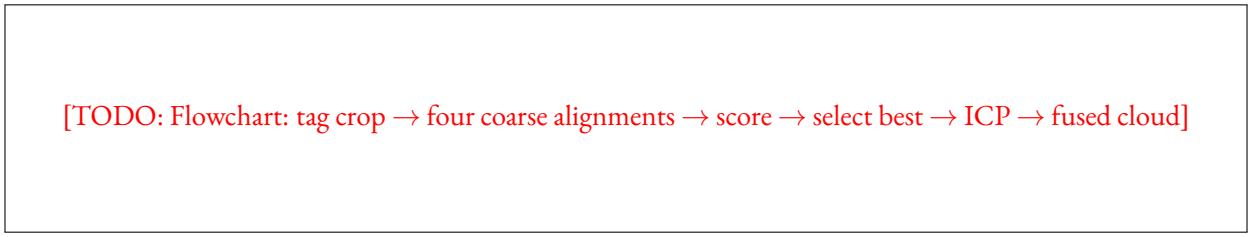


Figure 4.2: Multi-angle fusion pipeline.

4.4 Software Architecture and Processing Pipeline

4.4.1 Capture Software

Capture is implemented in C++ utilising the RealSense SDK. For each rig pose, it applies a configurable chain of depth post-processing filters and records the stream to a `.db3` file, together with IMU data. It detects the four AprilTags in the colour image, and the best frame of each pose is exported as a point cloud in PLY format. [TODO: State the filters used and their parameters, or reference the characterisation chapter.] Tag detection is stored along side captures for use of later processing through cropping and alignment.

4.4.2 Cropping and Multi-Angle Fusion

Each scan is first cropped to the square defined by the four tags. The cropped scans, taken at different tilt and rotation settings, are then fused (Figure 4.2). Fusion needs a good initial pose before refinement, so the pipeline generates several *coarse* alignment hypotheses by independent methods:

1. from the detected tag locations;
2. from the known rotation and servo tilt angle set on the rig;
3. from the camera IMU orientation;
4. from RANSAC matching of FPFH features [**?** **?**].

Each hypothesis is scored with a common alignment-quality measure, and the highest-scoring one is selected. It is then refined with ICP [**?**] and the merged surface passes to the microtopography stage. Using four independent seeds makes the fusion robust to the failure mode of any single method (for example, feature matching on a nearly planar surface, or IMU drift).

4.4.3 Microtopography Processing

The fused surface is detrended to remove the large-scale slope of the sediment, giving the microtopography from which roughness metrics are computed. Mounds and burrow openings are then detected and segmented using classical morphological image processing. [TODO: One sentence each on the detrending method, the roughness metrics, and the segmentation approach; details belong in later chapters.]

4.5 Evaluation Framework and Ground Truth

For characterisation and validation, a separate Python tool, `evaluate_scans`, measures the geometric error of any scan, whether a single capture or the fused output, against a known reference. It reuses the structure of the fusion pipeline's alignment stage, but aligns each scan to the reference. The tool then evaluates scan accuracy and coverage against the reference object.

4.5.1 Reference Surfaces

The reference objects used for validation include a 3D printed egg carton surface $z = sin(x) + sin(y)$, at large and small scale, and a square based pyramid. These reference objects provide a balance of condition matching of the actual sediment surface, using the soft sinusoidal surface, and general performance to less natural sharp shapes. For the purpose of validation, the 3D model files (.stl) are used for evaluation as the 3D mesh surface allows for point to surface distance calculation across the entire 3D object.

4.5.2 Alignment and Metrics

Alignment uses several seeded feature-matching starts, systematic perturbations of the best pose (quarter turns, a flip, and slides of a quarter and half of the part), and point-to-plane ICP, followed by a final refinement against the exact surface. Candidate poses are ranked by a truncated least-squares cost computed in both directions (scan to reference and reference to scan), which prevents a pose that matches fewer points from winning by default. This matters on periodic targets such as the egg carton, where several look-alike poses exist. The tool flags a result as *ambiguous* when the two best poses are too close to call, and reports degrees of freedom the surface cannot constrain.

For each aligned scan the tool reports accuracy (RMSE, MAE, bias, standard deviation, trimmed statistics, percentiles), the vertical error for height-field references, and coverage of the reference. It also reports completeness, precision and F-score at several distance thresholds, Chamfer and Hausdorff distances, outlier fraction and point density. Every run appends a row to a shared table with the exact parameters, reference hash and random seed, so experiments are reproducible and comparable across configurations.

4.6 Summary

The rig provides repeatable, multi-angle capture of a user-defined surface region. The software fuses those scans, extracts microtopography, and is checked against analytic ground truth. Chapter [TODO: characterisation chapter ref] uses this system to characterise the D456's depth noise.

Chapter 5

Intel RealSense Characterisation

The aim of the overarching project is to produce high-accuracy reconstructions of intertidal sediment from which surface roughness metrics can be extracted. The accuracy of those metrics is limited by the depth data they are computed from, so the Intel RealSense D456 was characterised before the capture and processing pipeline was finalised. The characterisation answers four practical questions about how the camera and rig should be operated in situ: at what working distance, at what viewing angle, under what ambient lighting, and with which depth-stream and filter settings the camera produces the most accurate surface.

The characterisation was performed in two stages. In the first stage the camera was tested against flat planar targets. A plane has an exact, easily measured ground truth, which allows the effect of working distance, tilt angle and ambient light to be isolated from the effect of surface shape. These tests give a baseline for sensor noise and provide the operating envelope used in the second stage. In the second stage the camera was tested against 3D-printed reference objects with known geometry (see Appendix B.) These tests identify the camera configuration, post-processing filter settings and combination of viewing directions that give the best reconstruction, using surface relief that is representative of the sediment of interest. Each characterisation below is presented with its method, results and a short discussion.

5.1 Plane Surface Characterisation

5.1.1 Capture procedure and metrics

All planar characterisation used custom C++ software built on the Intel RealSense SDK, following the plane-fit metrics of Intel's Depth Quality Tool. Details of each trial including: distance, tilt angle and a lux reading, are entered into the tool and the scan is started, after which approximately 600 frames are recorded. A region of interest (ROI) is then applied whose pixel size is adjusted with distance so that it always covers a fixed 50 × 50 cm area of the target. A plane is fitted to the ROI points of every frame and compared with the ground-truth plane. Frames flagged as repeated or as outliers were discarded, leaving roughly 400 to 600 valid frames per trial[TODO: confirm the same frame rejection was applied in all three sweeps]. Several metrics are reported by the tool, however there are four main metrics that will be discussed here to represent the general performance, each averaged over the valid frames of a trial:

- **Plane-fit RMS** (mm): the root-mean-square distance of the ROI points from the best-fit plane. This measures spatial noise and is independent of any constant offset in the depth.
- **Median depth error** (mm): the median signed difference between the measured and ground-truth depth, which measures systematic bias.
- **Fill rate** (%): the proportion of ROI pixels that returned a valid depth value.
- **Plane Distance Error** (mm): Error between perpendicular distance from camera to the fitted plane, and the ground truth.[TODO: is this a good metric?]

The distinction between precision and bias matters for this project. A smooth, systematic bias is removed when the fused surface is detrended to extract microtopography, whereas random noise adds directly to the measured roughness. Plane-fit

RMS and fill rate are therefore treated as the primary metric, with depth error and Plane Distance Error treated as secondary indicators. Each condition was recorded as a single trial. The frames within a trial capture temporal variation but not the repeatability of re-setting the experiment, which is discussed in section 5.3.

5.1.2 Planar Characterisation Methodology

Working distance

The camera was mounted on a tripod and pointed at a white, featureless wall, as recommended by Intel for depth-quality testing. This forces the camera to depend on its own projected infrared pattern. The tripod was used instead of the experimental rig because the rig's mounting brackets could not hold the camera sufficiently parallel to the floor: the camera angle varied with every scan and consistently exceeded 1.5°, which would have contaminated a distance sweep. The camera was positioned at eight distances between 604 mm and 903 mm, and the angle between the camera and the wall was minimised by hand at each position. The fitted-plane angle confirmed that the residual pitch and roll stayed below 0.5°in all trials. The ground-truth distance was measured between the wall and the cameras glass front using a tape measure.

[TODO: Maybe talk more about methodology?]

Camera tilt

The camera was mounted on the experimental rig so that its angle could be set with the tilt servo. A large flat white foam board was placed on the floor and re-centred in the field of view (FOV) after each change of angle. Two rotations were tested independently. The pitch axis is parallel to the line through the two IR imagers, and the roll axis is perpendicular to both the pitch axis and the optical axis. The angle was changed in steps of approximately 2°, covering pitch angles from $-27°$ to $-2°$ and roll angles from $+3°$ to $+25°$ for 26 trials in total[TODO: confirm that the opposite signs were not recorded, or add them]. The camera mount height was kept fixed. For each trial the vertical height of the left IR imager, the centre of the resulting depth image, above the board was measured, and the axial ground-truth distance was calculated from that height and the tilt angle. This axial distance varied between 657 mm and 743 mm over the sweep. The angle of the fitted plane agreed with the set angle to within 1° in every trial (mean 0.4°), which verifies the angle settings.

[TODO: Maybe talk more about methodology?]

Ambient lighting

The same foam board was scanned at a camera height of approximately 900 ,m under a range of lighting conditions, with the camera exposure left on automatic. Indoor conditions ranged from a dark room in the evening (blinds closed, lights off) to an afternoon room with the blinds open and the lights on. Outdoor trials were performed around midday in shade, in shade within direct sunlight, and in direct sunlight. The outdoor trials were taken twice per condition, one with the foam board, and one without the foam board. This was done as the effects of the high ambient light resulted in exposure settings that were unable to detect the cameras built in projected pattern, and thus the featureless white surface lost detection. The brick flooring was able to be detected in this condition, thus the results for the outdoor trials provide relational performance compare to the rest of the trials. Illuminance was read with a smartphone running the Physics Toolbox Suite application, which uses the front camera as a lux meter. Such readings are uncalibrated and are used here to indicate the order of magnitude and ranking of conditions, not precise values. The lux was recorded as 0 in the darkest condition and 24 400 in full sun.

[TODO: Maybe talk more about methodology?]

5.1.3 Planar testing Results

Working Distance

Results from this characterisation are shown in Table 5.1 [TODO: get statistical results for these measurements]. These are then plotted in [TODO: reference plots]

Table 5.1: Planar characterisation against a white wall at different working distances (one trial per distance; values averaged over the valid frames).

Distance (mm)	Plane-fit RMS (mm)	RMS (% of dist.)	Median depth error (mm)	Fill rate (%)	Plane dist. error (mm)
604	1.22	0.20	4.7	99.6	1
628	1.29	0.20	4.7	99.5	1
667	1.56	0.23	6.4	99.5	3
723	2.64	0.36	5.5	97.7	4
760	2.81	0.37	6.0	97.7	5
821	3.27	0.39	7.7	97.3	6
880	4.06	0.46	7.2	96.9	7
903	4.58	0.50	8.0	96.5	8

[TODO: Figure: plane-fit RMS and fill rate versus distance, with the power-law fit overlaid]

Camera Tilt

[TODO: Figure: plane-fit RMS versus tilt angle for pitch and roll, with the range-predicted curve overlaid] Plane-fit RMS was lowest near 0° (about 1.6 mm) and rose to 2.30 mm at $-27°$ pitch and 2.12 mm at $+25°$ roll. The fill rate stayed between 98.4% and 99.5%. The median depth error varied between 5 mm and 11 mm without a clear dependence on angle. Trials at almost the same angle differed by up to 6 mm (5.0 mm at $-26.8°$ against 10.7 mm at $-27.3°$ pitch).

Ambient Lighting

The results are listed in Table 5.2. Indoors, plane-fit RMS increased with illumination from 1.80 mm in darkness to 4.44 mm at 151 lux, and the fill rate fell from 99.9% to 96.3%. Adding artificial light increased the noise within both the evening session (1.80 to 2.84 mm) and the afternoon session (2.73 to 3.44 mm). Outdoors, the foam board in shade (388 lux) returned only 86.5% valid pixels and a plane-fit RMS of 6.00 mm. In direct sunlight (2 650 and 24 400 lux) no valid plane could be recovered, with fill rates of 3.7% and 5.4%. The ground surface without the board returned a 100% fill rate in all three outdoor conditions, including direct sun at around 10 000 lux, with a plane-fit RMS of 1.1 to 1.2 mm.

5.1.4 Discusion

Working Distance

Stereo triangulation noise is expected to grow with the square of the range. A power-law fit to these data gives an exponent of approximately 3.3, which is steeper than expected. Part of the difference may come from the ambient light, which was not constant across the sweep. The auto-exposure value dropped from around 5300 for the three closest distances to between 1700 and 2050 for the remainder, and the largest step in noise (from 1.56 mm to 2.64 mm) coincides with this change. The trials were recorded in a different order to their distance (between about 15:40 and 17:35), so distance and ambient light are partly confounded. Even allowing for this, the trend is clear: noise grows rapidly with working distance, so the camera should be operated at the shortest distance that still frames the analysis region. The roughly constant relative depth error of about 0.8% is consistent with a scale or ground-truth referencing offset rather than a distance-dependent effect. It does not affect the roughness metrics, but it would appear as a scale error in an absolute reconstruction, which the 3D reference tests in Section **??** quantify.

Table 5.2: Planar characterisation under different lighting conditions at a height of approximately 0.9 m. Lux values are indicative (smartphone sensor). A dash indicates that no valid plane fit was obtained.

Surface	Condition	Lux	Fill rate (%)	Plane-fit RMS (mm)	Median depth error (m
Indoor foam board	Evening, blinds closed, lights off	0	99.9	1.80	4.9
	Afternoon, blinds closed, lights off	17	99.4	2.73	7.3
	Evening, blinds closed, lights on	65	99.3	2.84	5.2
	Afternoon, blinds closed, lights on	78	98.7	3.44	7.3
	Afternoon, blinds open, lights off	91	97.0	4.14	7.1
	Afternoon, blinds open, lights on	151	96.3	4.44	7.5
Outdoor foam board	Shade	388	86.5	6.00	−2.5
	Direct sun, under shade	2 650	3.7	–	–
	Direct sun	24 400	5.4	–	–
Outdoor, no board	Shade	213	100	1.20	5.7
	Direct sun	9 800	100	1.09	4.6
	Direct sun, under shade	10 000	100	1.17	4.3

Camera Tilt

Because the camera pivots, tilting it also increases the axial distance to the board. When the power law from the distance sweep is applied to the measured axial distance of each trial, the predicted plane-fit RMS matches the observed value to within about 7% (for example 2.42 mm predicted against 2.30 mm observed at $-27.3°$, and 2.04 mm against 2.12 mm at $+25.3°$). The increase in noise with tilt over $\pm 25°$ can therefore be explained almost entirely by the longer range, and tilt itself does not appear to degrade the depth significantly. This is the result needed to justify multi-view scanning, since oblique views add information about occluded relief at little cost in noise. The scatter in depth error between neighbouring angles, which is larger than any trend, points to the repeatability of the experimental set-up (re-positioning the board and measuring its height) as the dominant source of uncertainty in this metric, and the depth-error values should be read with that in mind. A flat board cannot reveal the effects of foreshortening and self-occlusion on relief, which are examined with the 3D reference objects.

Ambient Lighting

Two conclusions follow. First, ambient light degrades the depth from active stereo even when the surface is well within the sensor's range, because the projected infrared pattern has to compete with the ambient light for contrast. Daylight appears more damaging per lux than artificial light (4.14 mm at 91 lux of daylight against 2.84 mm at 65 lux of artificial light), which is consistent with the greater near-infrared content of sunlight, so illuminance in lux is only a rough predictor of performance. Second, the surface matters as much as the illumination. The board failed at 2 650 lux, whereas the ground surface returned complete, low-noise data at 9 800 lux, so the failure cannot be attributed to the light level alone. A bright, featureless, highly reflective white surface is a worst case for stereo matching. The ground surface supplies natural texture, so the planar results on white targets should be read as pessimistic bounds on the noise expected on sediment. The outdoor tests did not include a matched pair of lux levels for the two surfaces, and wet or glossy sediment, which is more specular, was not tested. These results support retaining the shading tarp on the rig, which the Chapter **??** design already includes, to limit the ambient infrared reaching the scan area[TODO: check the label of the System Design chapter].

5.2 3D Reference Characterisation

The planar tests establish the sensor's noise behaviour but not how accurately it reconstructs three-dimensional relief, which is affected by resolution, filtering, foreshortening and the fusion of several views. These effects were measured against reference objects with known geometry using a modified version of the main capture program, which records scans under controlled software settings and hardware set-ups.

5.2.1 Reference objects and evaluation

Three 3D-printed reference objects were used (Appendix [TODO: ref]). Each has a 100 × 100 mm footprint. Two are sinusoidal "egg carton" surfaces of the form $z = \sin(x) + \sin(y)$ at a large scale (feature spacing 50 mm) and a small scale (25 mm), and the third is a square-based pyramid of 50 mm height[TODO: confirm the egg carton amplitude and wavelength against the CAD drawings]. The smooth sinusoidal surfaces approximate the mounds produced by sand prawns, whose heights of 3 to 5 cm were reported in the literature review, and the small carton tests the lateral resolution of the camera. The pyramid has sharp edges and planar facets, which show whether the filters preserve geometric edges or smooth them.

Scans were evaluated with the `evaluate_scans` tool described in Chapter **??**[TODO: Section ref]. The tool rigidly aligns each scan to the reference .stl model, using feature-matching starts followed by point-to-plane ICP, and then computes point-to-surface distances. Scale is not estimated, so any scale error in the camera data appears as geometric error. The metrics used are RMSE, mean absolute error, bias and standard deviation of the point-to-surface distance, the completeness, precision and F-score at distance thresholds of 0.5, 1, 2 and 5 mm, and the fraction of the reference surface covered. Every evaluation logs its parameters, reference hash and random seed, so all results can be reproduced and compared directly.

5.2.2 Testing Procedure

Camera configuration

The first sweep fixed the height and tilt of the camera and scanned the large egg carton and the pyramid with different stream configurations. The resolution ranged from 1280 × 720 to 640 × 360 pixels, the depth units from 0.001 m to 0.0001 m, and all of the built-in visual presets were tested except the Hand preset, which is intended for gesture tracking. The depth unit sets the quantisation step of the 16-bit depth values, and the finest setting (0.1 mm) still provides a maximum range of 6.5 m, well beyond the working distance. [TODO: Results table: RMSE, completeness and F-score for each resolution, depth unit and preset on both objects, plus one or two sentences of discussion]

Based on this sweep, a resolution of 1280 × 720, a depth unit of 0.0001 m and the High Density preset were used for all later scans[TODO: confirm that this was the outcome of the sweep]. These are the settings listed in Chapter **??**.

Post-processing filters

With the configuration fixed, five stationary scans of each object were recorded at each of the tested heights, without tilt or rotation. The data were recorded to file so that the RealSense post-processing filters could be applied offline in many combinations to the same scans (Grunnet-Jepsen and Tong [TODO: cite]). The filters were decimation, spatial, temporal and hole-filling, and a sweep was made over their smoothing alpha, smoothing delta and magnitude parameters[TODO: list the values or ranges tested for each filter]. Decimation reduces the resolution, the spatial filter performs edge-preserving smoothing, the temporal filter averages depth across frames, and hole filling interpolates invalid pixels. Each combination was evaluated against the reference, and the process was repeated at each height to determine whether the best filter settings depend on the working distance. [TODO: Results: best-performing settings per height and object, and the trade-off between noise reduction and loss of fine relief or edges]

Tilt and rotation

Finally, a full scan of each object was recorded at rotations of $-45°$, $0°$, $45°$ and $90°$ and at tilts from $-25°$ to $+25°$ in steps of $5°$. This gives 44 views of each object. Offline, these views were aligned and fused by the pipeline in Chapter **??**. For each view, several coarse alignment hypotheses are generated (from the IMU orientation, the detected AprilTag positions, the known rotation and tilt settings, and RANSAC matching of FPFH features) and scored. The best hypothesis is refined with ICP and the aligned scans are merged[TODO: expand once the fusion method is finalised]. Subsets of the views were fused and each fusion was evaluated against the reference, which shows how the reconstruction accuracy depends on the number of views and on the combination of tilt and rotation. [TODO: Results: accuracy and coverage versus the views included, and the recommended tilt and rotation set]

5.2.3 3D Characterisation Results

Camera Configuration

Filters

Tilt and Rotation

5.3 Chapter Summary

This chapter characterised the Intel RealSense D456 in two stages. The planar tests showed that depth noise grows rapidly with distance (from 1.2 mm at 604 mm to 4.6 mm at 903 mm), so the working distance should be as short as the analysis region allows. Tilts of up to about $\pm 25°$ add little noise beyond that caused by the increased range, which supports a multi-view strategy. Ambient light increases noise, and the white foam board failed in direct sun while a textured ground surface did not, so the tarp shading and the textured nature of sediment are both important. The 3D reference tests then fix the stream configuration, filter settings and view combinations used in the remainder of the project.

The results have limitations that affect how they should be used. Each condition was recorded once, so the effect of re-setting the experiment is not quantified, and the scatter in depth error between neighbouring tilt angles suggests that it is significant. The distance sweep was not recorded in order of distance and the lighting changed between sessions, so distance and ambient light are partly confounded. The lux values come from an uncalibrated smartphone sensor. The distance sweep was performed with a tripod because the rig brackets could not hold the camera level, and the white featureless planar targets are likely to overstate the noise expected on textured sediment. Wet and specular sediment has not yet been tested. These points are taken up in Chapter **??**[TODO: ref to Further work].

Chapter 6

Data Processing Pipeline

The capture stage (Chapter **??**) [TODO: check label] produces one *session* per experiment. A session is a set of roughly 28 *scans* of the same patch of sediment, one per combination of mount rotation and tilt. Each scan stores the single best depth frame as a coloured point cloud (`.ply`), together with the AprilTag detections for the whole recording (`*_detections.csv`), the IMU sample taken with the best frame (`imu_a<tilt>.csv`), the full recording (`.db3`) and a text dump of the camera configuration (`scan_info.txt`).

A single scan is not a good measurement of the surface by itself. It contains the rig, the tags and everything else in the camera's wide field of view. It is noisy, particularly where the surface is seen at a grazing angle. It also has holes wherever relief hides part of the surface from that viewpoint. The processing pipeline turns a session of such scans into a single, clean reconstruction of the region of interest and then into numbers that describe its roughness. It has four stages (Figure **??**):

1. **Cropping** (Section **??**) cuts every scan down to the square of sediment bounded by the four corner AprilTags.
2. **Fusion** (Section **??**) registers the cropped scans into one common coordinate frame and merges their overlapping regions into a single, lower-noise surface with fewer holes.
3. **Roughness estimation** (Section **??**) levels and detrends the fused surface and computes standardised surface-texture parameters, including rugosity.
4. **Feature detection** (Section **??**) locates and counts discrete features such as sandprawn burrow openings.

Each stage is a separate program that reads the previous stage's output files, so any stage can be rerun or inspected on its own. The language of each program was chosen for its workload. Cropping is mostly bookkeeping and image geometry, so it is written in Python with Open3D [**?**] and NumPy. Fusion runs nearest-neighbour searches, feature matching and iterative registration on millions of points, so it is written in C++ with the Point Cloud Library (PCL) [**?**]. The roughness metrics are array operations on a regular grid and are written in Python with NumPy and SciPy. A small Python script (`bulk_process.py`) chains cropping and fusion over many sessions without user interaction, which is how the experimental data sets in Chapter **??** [TODO: check label] were processed.

[TODO: []inline]Figure: block diagram. Capture outputs (PLY, detections.csv, IMU, .db3, scan_info.txt) → crop_pointclouds.py (cropped PLY + tag sidecar) → fuse_scans (one fused PLY per session) → roughness_scans.py (metrics.json, CSV, height maps) → feature detection.

Figure 6.1: Overview of the data processing pipeline and the files passed between stages.

6.1 Point Cloud Cropping

6.1.1 Why the scans are cropped

The raw point clouds have three problems that make them unsuitable for direct use.

1. **The field of view is larger than the region of interest.** The Intel RealSense D456 has a wide field of view, so even with the camera pointed straight down it records depth well outside the patch of sediment inside the experimental rig.
2. **The view changes with every scan.** Because the camera is carried on a rotating and tilting mount, tilted scans look past the edge of the rig and often capture the rig frame itself. These points do not belong to the surface and would corrupt both registration and the roughness statistics.
3. **Large scans are expensive and overlap poorly.** Fusion compares every scan with every other scan already placed. Points outside the shared region add computation without adding information. Worse, regions that only one scan sees can pull a registration towards a wrong answer.

The cropping step therefore reduces every scan to the same physical region: the square on the sediment bed whose corners are marked by four AprilTags. Because the tags are fixed in the world, this region is the same in every scan regardless of how the camera was rotated or tilted. This gives fusion a consistent, well-overlapping input. The step is implemented in `crop_pointclouds.py`, which processes an entire session at once. It crops automatically wherever it can and falls back to a manual crop when it cannot.

6.1.2 Finding the tags in each scan

AprilTag detection is performed during capture on the colour image, and every detection is written to `*_detections.csv` together with the frame number, the tag ID and the pixel coordinates of the tag's centre and four corners. Squares that look like tags but whose ID could not be decoded are also logged, with an ID of -1.

The point cloud of a scan comes from one particular frame of the recording. The cropper reads that frame number from the scan's IMU file, which was written at the same moment as the point cloud. It then collects the detections from that frame. A tag that flickered out of the exported frame is taken from the nearest frame within ± 15 frames in which it was detected. This is valid because the camera is stationary for the whole of a scan, so a tag's position in the image does not change between nearby frames. Decoded tags are always preferred. Undecoded squares are used only to fill a corner that no decoded tag covers, and only when they lie close to where the missing tag is expected.

6.1.3 Learning the tag layout of a session

The four tags will not be found in every scan. Glare, shadow or a steep tilt often hide one or two of them. To crop such scans anyway, the program first learns the layout of the tags from the scans in the session where all four were detected. From those frames it records:

- the order in which the four tag IDs appear going around the square, which says which tags share a side and which are diagonal;
- the ratio of the square's side length to a tag's side length;
- the aspect ratio of the square, i.e. how each side compares to its neighbours.

The median of each quantity over all four-tag frames is used, which makes the layout robust to a few poor detections. With this layout, missing corners can be predicted from the tags that were seen. With three tags, the fourth is placed to complete a parallelogram, $\mathbf{p}_4 = \mathbf{p}_1 + \mathbf{p}_3 - \mathbf{p}_2$. With two tags on the same side, the square is completed by stepping perpendicular to that side by the learned aspect ratio. With two diagonal tags, the side vector is solved from the diagonal and the aspect ratio before stepping out in the same way.

The crop region is then defined by the *inner* corner of each tag, i.e. the corner nearest the centre of the square. This places the crop boundary just inside the tags, so the tags themselves are removed along with everything outside them.

6.1.4 Relating 3D points to image pixels

The tag positions are known in the 2D colour image, but the crop has to be applied to 3D points. The two are linked through the camera model. During capture the depth image is aligned to the colour image before the point cloud is exported, so every 3D point originates from one integer pixel of the colour image. The cropper reads the colour camera intrinsics (focal lengths f_x, f_y, principal point (c_x, c_y) and distortion coefficients) directly from the scan's recording file and projects every point back into the image. A point (X, Y, Z) in the camera frame maps to

$$u = f_x\, x_d + c_x, \qquad v = f_y\, y_d + c_y, \tag{6.1}$$

where (x_d, y_d) are the normalised coordinates $(X/Z,\ Y/Z)$ after lens distortion has been applied. The distortion is computed exactly as the RealSense SDK computes it, which differs slightly from the textbook Brown–Conrady model. Using the SDK's form reprojects the cloud onto the pixel grid to within about 10^{-5} pixels, compared with about 10^{-2} pixels for the textbook form.

This property also provides a self-check. If the intrinsics really belong to this cloud, every reprojected point should land almost exactly on an integer pixel. The cropper measures the root-mean-square distance of the reprojected points from the nearest pixel centre,

$$\rho = \sqrt{\frac{1}{N}\sum_{i=1}^{N} \left\| \mathbf{u}_i - \operatorname{round}(\mathbf{u}_i) \right\|^2}, \tag{6.2}$$

and rejects the automatic crop if ρ exceeds 0.15 pixels. The same test is used to choose how the distortion coefficients should be applied, since the stored coefficients can describe either the forward or the inverse distortion. The interpretation with the smallest ρ is kept. This guards against silently cropping a scan with the wrong camera model, for example if a recording was captured with a different resolution.

6.1.5 Building the crop volume

The simplest crop would keep every point whose pixel falls inside the tag-bounded quadrilateral. This is equivalent to cutting the cloud with a pyramid whose apex is at the camera. The walls of that pyramid follow the camera's lines of sight, so a tilted scan would be cut along a different boundary on the sediment than an untilted scan, and the scans would no longer cover the same region.

Instead, the cropper builds a vertical *prism* through the tag corners, so that the crop boundary is the same physical line on the bed for every scan:

1. **Fit the bed surface.** A plane is fitted to the points in a narrow band (25 pixels) just inside the crop edge. The band is used rather than the whole region so that the test object or sediment relief in the middle of the square does not influence the fit. The fit uses RANSAC [**?**]: planes through three randomly chosen points are tried 500 times, and the plane with the most points within 5 mm of it is kept. RANSAC is used because it ignores outliers entirely instead of averaging them in, which matters near the edge of the crop where stray points from the rig may remain.

2. **Fit the tag plane.** A second RANSAC plane is fitted to the points lying on the tags themselves. The tags can sit slightly above the sediment, so the 3D corners of the crop region are placed where the pixel rays through the inner tag corners meet this plane. For a pixel ray with direction $\mathbf{r}$ and a plane with normal $\mathbf{n}$ and offset d, the intersection is

$$\mathbf{X} = \frac{-d}{\mathbf{n}\cdot\mathbf{r}}\,\mathbf{r}. \tag{6.3}$$

3. **Extrude along the surface normal.** All points are projected onto the bed plane, and a point is kept if its projection falls inside the four 3D corners. The result is a column whose walls are perpendicular to the bed and pass through the inner tag corners, independent of the camera's viewing angle.

If no bed plane can be found, the cropper falls back to the pyramid crop described above and notes this in its output. A crop that keeps fewer than 1000 points is treated as a failure.

6.1.6 Review and manual fallback

Unless run in batch mode, each automatic crop is shown in a preview window with the removed points dimmed and the crop boundary drawn as a wireframe. The user can accept it, keep the original cloud, or switch to a manual crop. The manual crop starts from points the user picks in the viewer and then lets the box be moved and resized with the keyboard. It is also used whenever the automatic crop fails, for example when fewer than two tags were detected. This keeps a person in the loop for the cases where automatic tag detection is least reliable.

6.1.7 Outputs

For each scan the cropper writes:

- **The cropped point cloud**, in the same coordinate frame as the input. It is written with 32-bit floating-point coordinates, because Open3D's default writer produces 64-bit coordinates that the PCL-based fusion program fails to read.
- **A tag sidecar file** (`*_tags.csv`) giving the 3D positions of the four corners of every visible tag. Cropping removes the tags from the cloud, but fusion can use them for alignment (Section **??**), so their positions are measured on the *uncropped* cloud before they are discarded. Each tag's pixel corners are taken as the median over every frame of the recording, which removes detector jitter. A plane is fitted by least squares to the depth points on the central 70% of the tag; the border is excluded because pixels there mix tag and background depth. The 3D corners are the intersections of the corner pixel rays with that plane. This is more accurate than reading the single depth value at each corner, which is exactly where depth is least reliable.
- **Copies of the IMU, detection and configuration files**, so that the cropped session has the same folder layout as a raw session and can be passed to fusion unchanged.

6.1.8 Limitations

The automatic crop assumes that the sediment near the edge of the square is roughly flat, so that the band plane represents the bed. If relief reaches the crop edge, the fitted plane, and therefore the prism, can tilt. The layout learned from four-tag frames is pooled across all poses, although perspective changes with tilt, so corners extrapolated from only two tags in a strongly tilted view may be slightly misplaced. The prism also has no height limit, so isolated noisy points directly above or below the square are kept; these are removed later during fusion.

6.2 Multi-Scan Fusion

6.2.1 Why the scans are fused

Each scan sees the surface from one viewpoint. It is noisy, the noise is largest where the surface is seen at a grazing angle, and wherever relief blocks the line of sight there is no data at all. The rig captures the same patch from many rotations and tilts, so a region that is hidden or poorly measured in one scan is usually seen well in another. Fusion combines the scans so that each region of the surface is represented by its best measurements. This requires solving two problems: *registration*, which finds the rigid transformation (rotation and translation) that places each scan in a common coordinate frame, and *reconciliation*, which merges the overlapping measurements into a single surface.

Fusion is performed by a C++ program, `fuse_scans`. It runs as a sequence of stages: load and preprocess, estimate initial poses from the rig, coarse alignment, fine registration and reconciliation. The program can stop after coarse and after fine

alignment to show every scan in an interactive viewer, colour-coded and listed with its alignment quality. From there the user can exclude a bad scan, nudge one into place by hand, or rerun a stage, before the session is fused. In batch processing these reviews are skipped.

The common frame is that of the first untilted scan, called the *reference*. The remaining scans are processed in order of increasing tilt, so that each new scan is as similar as possible to what has already been placed.

6.2.2 Preprocessing

Each cropped cloud is first thinned with a voxel grid of 3 mm: space is divided into 3 mm cubes and all points in a cube are replaced by their centroid. This makes the density uniform, which most of the later algorithms assume, and it greatly reduces their cost. It also sets the finest detail the fused result can contain, so the voxel size is chosen close to the noise floor of the sensor. A statistical outlier filter then removes isolated points, defined as points whose mean distance to their 30 nearest neighbours is more than one standard deviation above the average.

Finally, a surface normal is estimated at every point from the principal axes of its neighbourhood within 15 mm. All normals are oriented to point towards the camera. This matters later: normals from several scans are averaged, and a normal and its opposite would cancel. The normals are computed once here and carried through every later transformation, because re-estimating them inside registration accounted for most of the program's run time.

6.2.3 Initial poses from the rig and IMU

Registration algorithms only converge when they start close to the right answer. The rig provides a natural starting point, because each scan's folder name records the commanded rotation and tilt. These commanded angles proved to be inaccurate, however. Commanded tilts of 15° produced measured tilts between 13.6° and 17.4°, and individual steps varied from 0.6 to 1.24 times the commanded step. In addition, because the rotating mount sits on top of the tilt stage, the tilt axis appears in a different direction in the camera frame for every rotation position, so a single fixed tilt axis cannot describe the rig.

The tilt is therefore *measured* rather than assumed. When the camera is stationary its accelerometer reads only gravity. The rotation that carries the gravity vector of a scan onto the gravity vector of the flattest scan at the same rotation position is exactly the tilt the mount applied, because the hinge axis is horizontal. Gravity readings with a magnitude outside 9.0–10.6 m/s^2 are rejected, since they indicate the camera was moving.

Two further quantities cannot be read from the IMU and are found by search:

- **The IMU-to-cloud axis convention.** The accelerometer and the exported point cloud use different axis conventions. Four candidate conventions (the identity and a 180° flip about each axis) are tried. For each, a few low-tilt scans are placed using the IMU tilt and compared with the reference scan. The convention with the best agreement is kept. On real data the correct convention gave residuals of 7–18 mm, against 42–76 mm for the wrong one.
- **The tilt pivot.** The IMU gives the angle of tilt but not the point the camera tilts about. The pivot is found by a coarse-to-fine grid search over a 0.12 m range, again scoring how well the placed scans agree with the reference. The convention and the pivot are searched together because an error in either can mask an error in the other.

The rotation direction poses a different problem. Every rotation folder is named with a positive angle, regardless of which way the mount actually turned, and the IMU cannot help, because a rotation about the gravity direction does not change the gravity reading. The program therefore tries every combination of clockwise and anticlockwise steps (up to 2^{12} combinations), places one representative scan per rotation position accordingly, and keeps the combination under which the scans agree best. A joint search is used rather than deciding each step on its own, because a wrong early step makes all later steps fit worse, which only a joint search can detect. When AprilTag alignment is enabled, the tags measure the rotation angle of each rotation position directly, and the search is needed only for positions where no tags were seen.

6.2.4 Coarse alignment

The coarse stage places each scan to within a few millimetres of its final position. Scans are added one at a time, and each is aligned against a *map* built from every scan placed so far, rather than against only the previous scan. This reduces the accumulation of error (drift) along the sequence. Up to three candidate poses, or hypotheses, are generated for each scan:

1. **The rig seed**: the pose predicted by the measured tilt and inferred rotation of Section **??**.
2. **The AprilTag pose**, if tag alignment is enabled. Each tag contributes four 3D corners from the sidecar file, which are matched against the same tag corners already placed in the common frame. The best rigid transformation between the matched corners is found in closed form with the method of Umeyama [**?**], which uses a singular value decomposition of the corners' cross-covariance matrix. No scale term is estimated, because both point sets are already in metres. When gravity is available, a constrained version is used instead: the tilt is taken from the IMU and only the turn about the vertical axis and the translation are solved from the tags. The tags a scan sees often lie nearly in a line, so the tilt about that line would otherwise rest on depth noise across a single 80 mm tag, whereas the IMU measures tilt well. On one test session this reduced the disagreement between tag poses and the final registered poses from 1–2.5° to 0.2–0.6°.
3. **A feature-based pose**, computed only if the rig seed overlaps the map poorly. Fast Point Feature Histograms (FPFH) [**?**] describe the local shape around every point. Points with similar descriptors in the scan and the map are paired, and a RANSAC variant [**?**] repeatedly picks three pairs, rejects them early if the triangles they form have different shapes, and keeps the transformation that brings the most points into agreement. This method needs no initial guess, but it is unreliable on smooth, nearly flat sediment with few distinctive shapes, which is why it is only a fallback.

To choose between hypotheses, each is scored by comparing the transformed scan with the map. A sample of scan points is matched to the nearest map point. Points within 10 mm are counted as overlapping, and the score is the root-mean-square distance of the overlapping points divided by the fraction of points that overlap. Lower is better. Dividing by the overlap fraction prevents a hypothesis from scoring well by fitting a small sliver of the scan very tightly.

For nearly flat scenes such as the sediment bed, this nearest-neighbour score has a blind spot. If a scan is slid or spun within the plane of the bed, every point still has a nearby neighbour on the flat map, so the score hardly changes. In that case the program instead compares heights. Both clouds are expressed in the frame of the bed plane, binned onto a 10 mm grid, and the score is computed from the differences in mean height between corresponding cells. A 5 mm in-plane slide raised this height-field score by 36%, but the nearest-neighbour score by only 16%. Whether a scene counts as flat is decided once from the reference scan.

The rig seed is accepted directly if at least 15% of the scan overlaps the map. Only if it fails is FPFH tried, and the better of the two is kept. A tag hypothesis competes with the result on the same score. If the tag pose and the geometric pose disagree by more than 10°, a warning is printed, because a disagreement that large means that one of them is wrong, not merely imprecise.

6.2.5 Fine registration

The fine stage refines each coarse pose with the Iterative Closest Point (ICP) algorithm [**?**]. ICP alternates between pairing every scan point with its nearest map point and solving for the rigid transformation that minimises the distance between the pairs, until the pose stops changing. The point-to-plane form of ICP [**?**] is used, which minimises the distance of each scan point from the tangent plane at its paired map point rather than from the map point itself:

$$E(\mathbf{R}, \mathbf{t}) = \sum_{(i,j)} \Big((\mathbf{R}\mathbf{p}_i + \mathbf{t} - \mathbf{q}_j) \cdot \mathbf{n}_j \Big)^2, \tag{6.4}$$

where $\mathbf{p}_i$ is a scan point, $\mathbf{q}_j$ its paired map point, $\mathbf{n}_j$ the map normal, and $\mathbf{R}$, $\mathbf{t}$ the rotation and translation being solved for. Because of the voxel grid, a scan point and its true counterpart on the map are generally not the same physical point, only points on the same surface. Point-to-plane ICP lets points slide along the surface instead of penalising this offset, so it converges faster and more accurately on continuous surfaces than point-to-point ICP. Each step is solved with the linear

least-squares approximation of Low [**?**]. Pairs further apart than 20 mm are ignored, so a coarse pose must be within roughly this distance for ICP to recover it, and at most 60 iterations are run.

As in the coarse stage, each scan is registered against a map of all scans placed so far. The map is stored as a voxel grid in which each voxel keeps running sums of the positions and normals of every scan that falls into it. Every scan therefore carries equal weight in the map. An earlier version re-thinned the merged map after every scan, which gave the newest scan about half the weight wherever it overlapped, so the map followed the latest scan rather than the consensus.

After the stage, a scan is flagged for review if ICP failed to converge, hit its iteration limit, or scored more than 1.4 times worse than the median scan of the session. The threshold is relative because what counts as a good score depends on the voxel size, the sensor noise and the relief of the surface. A scan whose refinement fails keeps its coarse pose, so that it remains visible in the review instead of silently disappearing.

6.2.6 Reconciling the overlapping scans

Once registered, the scans could simply be combined into one cloud and thinned with a voxel grid. This was the original approach, and it gives a poor result. The remaining registration error (a few millimetres) is larger than the output voxel, so where scans overlap, their surfaces land in neighbouring voxels and survive as two or three slightly offset sheets. A statistical outlier filter cannot remove a duplicate sheet, because the duplicate is just as dense as the real surface. The fusion step therefore *reconciles* the scans: it decides, for each small patch of the surface, a single best height.

Weighting each measurement. Not all measurements are equally reliable, so each point i is given a weight

$$w_i = c_{s(i)} \cdot \max\bigl(0.05,\ |\hat{\mathbf{n}}_i \cdot \hat{\mathbf{v}}_i|\bigr) \cdot \min\left(1,\ \frac{r_0^2}{r_i^2}\right). \tag{6.5}$$

The first factor, $c_{s(i)}$, is the registration confidence of the scan the point came from, based on how much of the scan overlapped the map and how closely. The second factor is the cosine of the angle between the surface normal $\hat{\mathbf{n}}_i$ and the direction to the camera $\hat{\mathbf{v}}_i$; stereo depth error rises sharply when the surface is seen at a grazing angle, so such points are down-weighted. The third factor reflects the range r_i from the camera: the depth error of a stereo camera grows with the square of the range, so points beyond the reference range $r_0 = 0.6$ m are down-weighted accordingly.

Grouping measurements into cells. For a nearly flat scene the points are expressed in the frame of the bed plane and binned into 3 mm cells in the plane, each holding the heights of all points that fall into it. This *height-field* mode is chosen automatically when the scene is flat, which applies to the sediment bed. Scenes with strong relief use a volumetric mode instead, in which points are binned into 3D voxels and reconciled along the local surface normal.

Choosing one value per cell. Within each cell, the measurements are combined with a *trimmed weighted mean*. The samples are sorted by height, and the lowest and highest 25% of the total weight are discarded before the weighted mean of the remainder is taken. A plain weighted mean would let a single misregistered scan drag the surface towards it, while a weighted median discards most of the information. The trimmed mean lies between the two. Trimming by weight rather than by count means that a single high-confidence measurement cannot be outvoted by several poor ones. On a synthetic test with one of four scans misregistered by 8 mm, the error of the fused surface was 2.00 mm with a plain weighted mean and 0.35 mm with the trimmed mean. Overall, reconciliation halved the error of the original merge-and-thin approach, from 0.96 mm to 0.45 mm RMS.

Removing off-surface outliers. Points that still lie off the surface are then removed. For each point a plane is fitted to its 31 nearest neighbours, and the point is discarded if its distance from that plane is more than three standard deviations above the average. This replaced the statistical outlier filter used earlier, which judges points by local density. That filter removed genuine but sparsely sampled parts of the surface and punched holes in the fused result, whereas the plane test only removes points that are actually off the surface.

Smoothing. Finally, the surface is smoothed with Moving Least Squares (MLS) [**? ?**]. Around each point, MLS fits a quadratic surface to the neighbours within 10 mm and moves the point onto it, which also yields a clean normal. Because the fitting radius is larger than the residual misregistration, this removes the last traces of offset sheets and sensor noise along the surface normal while keeping features larger than the radius. It is, however, a low-pass filter: relief with a wavelength comparable to or smaller than the 10 mm radius is attenuated. This must be kept in mind when interpreting the small-scale roughness parameters of Section **??**. [TODO: State whether the results in Ch. X were computed with or without MLS, and consider a short sensitivity check with `-no-mls`.]

The result is a single point cloud per session, in the frame of the reference scan, with one point per occupied cell and a normal at every point. The program also reports the thickness of the overlapping surface, i.e. the spread of heights within a cell, before and after reconciliation.

6.2.7 Limitations

Registration is sequential: each scan is aligned against the scans before it, and no global optimisation revisits earlier poses afterwards, so an early error can propagate. The rig seed is accepted whenever it overlaps the map by 15% or more. On a flat bed even a pose with a wrong rotation can overlap that much, in which case only the tag hypothesis can correct it, so tag alignment should be enabled for sediment scans. The pivot of the rotation stage is not estimated, so an offset between the turntable axis and the camera must be absorbed by the tags or by ICP. Finally, the height-field mode assumes the surface has a single height at every point, so overhangs and vertical faces, such as the inside walls of a burrow, are averaged away.

6.3 Surface Roughness Estimation

The roughness program, `roughness_scans.py`, takes a fused point cloud and describes the roughness of the surface it represents. No reference surface is required. It runs five steps: level the scan, crop it, remove large-scale trends, resample it onto a regular grid, and compute the metrics. Most of the metrics follow the areal surface-texture parameters of ISO 25178-2 [**?**], so that results can be compared with other surface-metrology studies. Internally all lengths are in metres; reported lengths are in millimetres.

6.3.1 Levelling

The fused scan is in the frame of the reference camera, so the sediment bed is generally tilted relative to the coordinate axes. Roughness parameters measure heights relative to a mean surface, so the scan is first levelled: rotated so that the mean plane of the bed is horizontal and height is measured along the z axis.

The mean plane is found by principal component analysis. The plane passes through the centroid of the points, and its normal is the direction in which the points vary least. To prevent large features from tilting the plane, the fit is repeated with sigma clipping: points further from the plane than three times a robust estimate of the spread are dropped and the plane is refitted, up to five times. The spread is estimated with the median absolute deviation (MAD), scaled by 1.4826 so that it equals the standard deviation for normally distributed data. Unlike the standard deviation, the MAD is barely affected by the points being clipped.

The levelled frame has its origin at the centroid, $+z$ along the plane normal pointing towards the camera, and x along the camera's original x axis projected onto the plane. Keeping the camera's horizontal direction means that the direction of ripples or other features reads the same in the results as in the images. The scan can then optionally be cropped to a region of interest or trimmed by a fixed margin around its border, where fused data are usually the sparsest.

6.3.2 Detrending

A levelled surface still contains variations that are not roughness: a gentle bowl in the sediment, a slope towards one side, or a residual tilt. In ISO 25178 terms these are removed by a form-removal operator, after which the remainder is treated as surface

texture. Here the form is modelled as a polynomial in the horizontal coordinates,

$$p(x, y) = \sum_{i+j \le n} a_{ij}\, x^i y^j, \tag{6.6}$$

of degree n from 1 (planar) to 4 (quartic), and the residual $z - p(x, y)$ is kept as the roughness surface. The coordinates are scaled to the range $[-1, 1]$ before fitting so that the fit remains numerically stable at higher degrees, and the same sigma clipping as in levelling stops ripple crests, troughs or burrow mounds from dragging the trend.

The choice of degree is a trade-off. A low degree may leave genuine form in the residual and overestimate roughness. A high degree can follow real bedforms: a polynomial of degree n can follow roughly $n/2$ wavelengths, so on a small patch it can remove relief that is part of the texture being measured. The program therefore computes the metrics for every degree requested, using the same levelling, crop and grid for each so that the results are directly comparable, and raises a warning if a higher-order fit removes much more height variance than the planar fit while the patch spans fewer than n dominant wavelengths. [TODO: State which detrend degree is used for the reported results and why.]

6.3.3 Gridding

Most roughness parameters are defined on a regular grid of heights, so the residual surface is resampled onto a square grid. By default the cell size is twice the median spacing between neighbouring points, so that most cells contain several points. The height of a cell is the mean of its points. Averaging c points with independent noise of standard deviation σ reduces the noise to $\sigma/\sqrt{c}$, so the gridding also acts as a mild low-pass filter at the scale of one cell.

Some cells contain no points. Small enclosed holes, no larger than two cells across, are filled by linear interpolation from the surrounding cells. Larger holes and gaps at the border are left empty and excluded from every metric, because interpolating across them would invent surface that was never measured.

6.3.4 Height parameters

With z_k the gridded heights relative to their mean and N the number of valid cells, the height parameters are:

$$S_a = \frac{1}{N} \sum_k |z_k|, \qquad S_q = \sqrt{\frac{1}{N} \sum_k z_k^2}, \tag{6.7}$$

$$S_{sk} = \frac{1}{S_q^3} \frac{1}{N} \sum_k z_k^3, \qquad S_{ku} = \frac{1}{S_q^4} \frac{1}{N} \sum_k z_k^4, \tag{6.8}$$

together with the highest peak S_p, the deepest valley S_v and the total height $S_z = S_p + S_v$. S_a and S_q are the arithmetic and root-mean-square heights and are the most common single measures of roughness. The skewness S_{sk} indicates whether the surface is dominated by peaks ($S_{sk} > 0$) or by pits ($S_{sk} < 0$); a bed riddled with burrow openings would be expected to have negative skewness. The kurtosis S_{ku} indicates how sharp the features are: a surface with normally distributed heights has $S_{ku} = 3$, while isolated sharp peaks or pits raise it.

6.3.5 Rugosity and slope

Rugosity is the ratio of the true area of a surface to the area of its projection onto the horizontal plane. It is the areal equivalent of the chain-and-tape method used in benthic ecology, in which a chain is laid along the contours of the bed and its length compared with the straight-line distance. A perfectly flat surface has a rugosity of exactly 1, and any relief raises it.

To compute the true area, each square of four neighbouring grid cells is split along a diagonal into two triangles, and the area of each triangle is computed from the cross product of its edges. Summing over all squares whose corners are valid gives

$$\text{rugosity} = \frac{\sum A_{\text{triangles}}}{N_q \, g^2}, \tag{6.9}$$

where N_q is the number of valid squares and g the grid spacing. The ISO 25178 developed interfacial area ratio is the same quantity expressed as a percentage excess, $S_{dr} = (\text{rugosity} - 1) \times 100\%$. The root-mean-square slope of the surface, S_{dq}, is computed from the same squares.

Rugosity, S_{dr} and S_{dq} all depend strongly on the grid spacing. Measurement noise adds small random slopes to every cell, and the finer the grid, the steeper those slopes become, so these parameters grow as the grid is refined even if the surface is unchanged. Results computed with different grid spacings are therefore not comparable, and all scans in this work are processed with the same spacing. [TODO: state the value used.]

6.3.6 Spatial and spectral parameters

The height parameters describe how tall features are, but not how large or how far apart they are. Two further groups of parameters capture this.

Autocorrelation. The autocorrelation function measures how similar the surface is to a copy of itself shifted horizontally. It equals 1 at zero shift and decays as the shift grows. The autocorrelation length S_{al} is the shortest shift at which it falls below 0.2, and gives the typical horizontal size of the features. The texture aspect ratio S_{tr} is the ratio of the shortest to the longest such distance over all directions: it is close to 1 for a surface that looks the same in every direction, such as a randomly burrowed bed, and close to 0 for a strongly directional one, such as a rippled bed. The autocorrelation is computed with the fast Fourier transform, counting only pairs of valid cells.

Power spectrum. The power spectral density (PSD) breaks the surface down into sinusoidal components and shows how much height variance each wavelength contributes. A Hann window is applied before the transform to reduce artefacts from the edges of the patch. The strongest peak of the PSD gives the dominant wavelength and direction of any regular pattern, such as ripples, and the texture direction S_{td} is reported as the direction of the crests. [TODO: Note: S_{td} here is the crest direction, i.e. 90° from the peak of the angular spectrum; check this against the convention of any software you compare with.] Many natural surfaces are *self-affine*: their PSD follows a power law $C(q) \propto q^{-2(1+H)}$ in wavenumber q over a wide range of scales [**?**]. Fitting a straight line to the log-log PSD gives the Hurst exponent H, which describes how roughness changes with scale, and the fractal dimension $D_f = 3 - H$. The fit is restricted to wavelengths between four grid cells, below which gridding distorts the spectrum, and a quarter of the patch width, above which there are too few repetitions to estimate the power reliably.

6.3.7 Additional measures and uncertainty

Several further outputs support the interpretation of the main parameters:

- **Multi-scale roughness.** S_q and rugosity are computed in square windows of increasing size, each with its own plane removed, to show how roughness depends on the scale of observation.
- **Confidence intervals.** 95% confidence intervals for S_q, S_{dr} and S_{al} are estimated with a block bootstrap: the surface is divided into square windows, which are resampled with replacement 1000 times. Neighbouring windows are correlated, so these intervals are likely to be somewhat optimistic.
- **Terrain ruggedness.** The Terrain Ruggedness Index [**?**] and the Vector Ruggedness Measure [**?**], widely used for seabed and landscape habitat analysis, are included for comparison with the ecological literature.

- **Noise correction.** Given an estimate of the sensor noise, either as a per-point standard deviation or from a scan of a flat plate processed in the same way, the noise contribution is subtracted from S_q and S_{dq}, assuming the noise adds independently to the true surface. A warning is raised if noise accounts for more than half of the measured slope, since rugosity then mainly measures noise.

All random choices use a fixed seed, so repeated runs give identical results, and every run records the hash of the code and of the input scan.

6.3.8 Validation

The program was checked in two ways. A test suite generates synthetic surfaces with known answers, such as sinusoids, for which S_q, S_a, the wavelength and even the exact rugosity follow in closed form, and random fractal surfaces with a prescribed Hurst exponent. Each metric is confirmed to recover the expected value, including when trends, noise, holes and a tilted camera are added. Secondly, a scan of a test object can be compared directly with its analytic definition: the reference surface is sampled, passed through exactly the same levelling, detrending and gridding, and the two sets of metrics are compared. This measures the error of the complete capture, fusion and roughness chain, and is used in Chapter **??** [TODO: check label].

6.3.9 Limitations

The parameters follow ISO 25178-2 definitions but are not fully ISO-conformant. The standard defines them on a surface that has been band-limited with Gaussian filters, whereas here the band is set implicitly by the grid cell, the MLS smoothing in fusion, the polynomial degree and the size of the patch. The values are therefore directly comparable between scans processed in this pipeline with the same settings, but should be compared with values from commercial surface-metrology software with care. The surface is also treated as a single-valued height map, so overhangs are lost.

6.4 Feature Detection

The roughness parameters describe the surface as a whole, but the biological question also requires counts of discrete features, in particular the burrow openings created by sandprawns. The final stage of the pipeline is intended to detect these automatically from the depth and colour images.

[TODO: Not yet implemented.]

Chapter 7

Experimental Validation

7.1 Known Relief and Controlled Targets

7.2 Roughness Metric Validation

Chapter 8

Results

8.1 Characterisation Results

8.2 Roughness Metric Results

8.3 Feature Segmentation Results

Chapter 9

Discussion

9.1 Optimal Configuration

9.2 Roughness Estimation

9.3 Feature Detection

Chapter 10

Conclusions

Chapter 11

Further work

11.1 Characterisation

11.2 Hardware Choices

Appendix A

GitHub repository

This appendix provides a link to the GitHub repository where the code and additional materials for this final year project report can be found.

A.1 Title for appendix A.1

- GitHub Repository: Repo name

Appendix B

Reference Objects

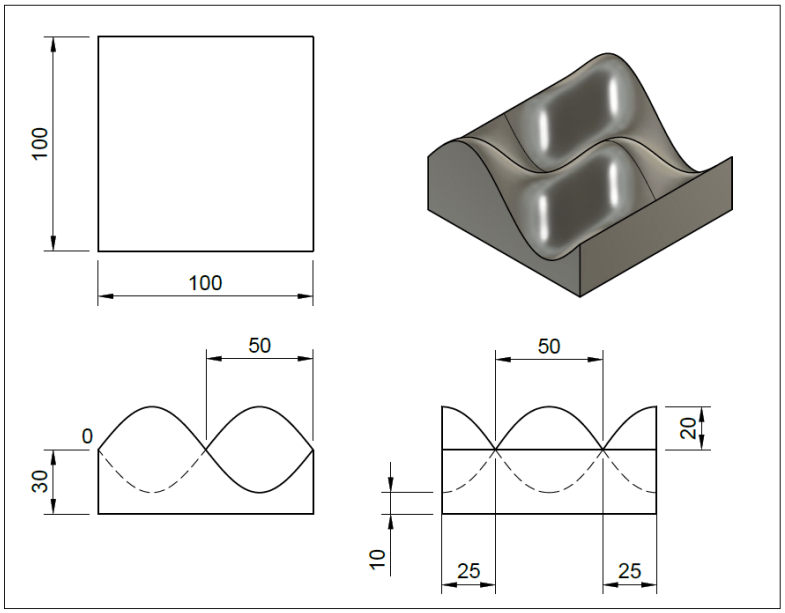


Figure B.1: Large Egg Box Surface Reference Object.

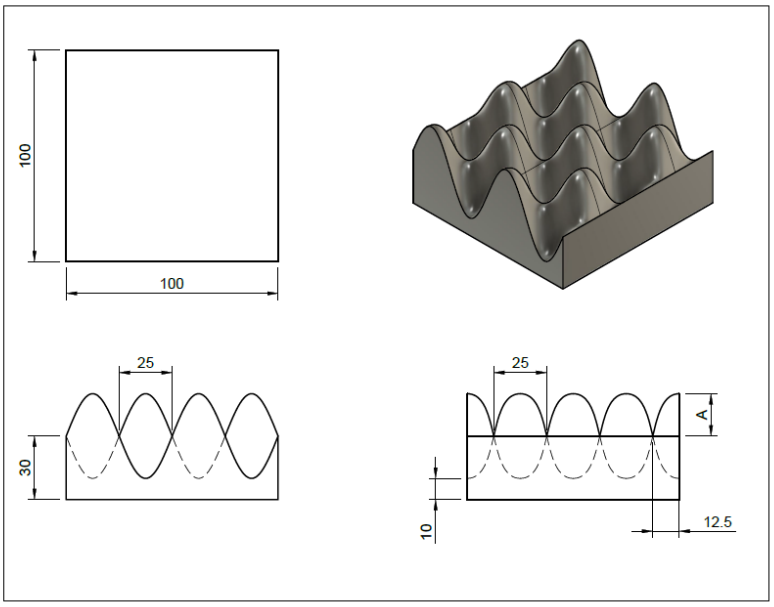


Figure B.2: Small Egg Box Surface Reference Object, Printed with amplitude A = 15mm.

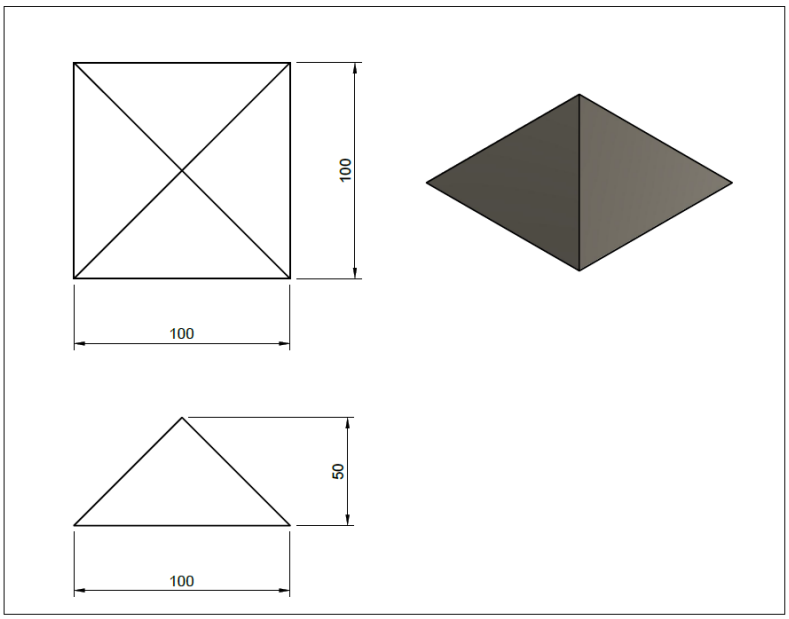


Figure B.3: Large Pyramid Surface Reference Object.

Appendix B: Ethics approval

Appendix C: Topic description

The original topic description used during the project selection process is included below. This topic has since been further refined, and the exact problem that was investigated is described in Section 1.2.

Appendix D: ECSA Graduate Attributes

Project mapping to ECSA Graduate Attributes

The table below provides a structured reflection on where each of the required Graduate Attributes (GAs) as defined by Engineering Council of South Africa (ECSA) associated with the final year project is met. This includes reference to the specific Chapter/Section (where applicable).

GA	Graduate Attribute Description	Student reflection: How this outcome was achieved during the project
GA1	*Problem solving*	
GA4	*Investigations, experiments and data analysis*	
GA5	*Use of engineering tools*	
GA6	*Professional and technical communication*	
GA8	*Individual and collaborative teamwork*	
GA9	*Independent learning ability*	

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